It is hard to capture the absurdity of the moment. Two prominent ministers offering their views on the most important issue for Israel's long-term survival as a Jewish state—one threatening to blow up the government, and the other happily offering him the dynamite. Clearly Lapid and Bennett could only coexist in the same cabinet if peace was low on the agenda—if Netanyahu, and the public at large, were content to preserve the status quo.

A senior member of his party made that point explicitly. "The conflict will not be solved in the near future," said Gideon Sa'ar, then the number-two man in Likud, speaking shortly after Lapid and Bennett. "The status quo is a better alternative, under these circumstances."

## *The teenagers*

The status quo survived for another four nights.

On 12 June, three Jewish teenagers—Eyal Yifrach, 19, Gilad Shaer, 16, and Naftali Fraenkel, 16—were heading home from their *yeshiva*, or religious seminary, in the occupied West Bank. They were hitchhiking, a common practice in a region where buses run infrequently. A Hyundai pulled up around 10.25pm and offered them a ride. The boys got in, and quickly realized their mistake—the drivers were two Palestinian men looking to abduct Israeli settlers. Shaer made a rushed phone call to police, whispering that he had been kidnapped. Moments later, the trio were dead.

Rumors of the abduction began to spread the next morning, and within twenty-four hours the boys were the subject of a major manhunt and nationwide concern. Their faces adorned the front pages of newspapers for days. Television news became an around-the-clock vigil, with correspondents obsessing over the latest tidbits of gossip. There were endless press conferences and statements, even a worldwide "Bring Back Our Boys" campaign on social media, appropriating a similar effort for the hundreds of Nigerian schoolgirls kidnapped by Boko Haram. Posters appeared across the country praying for their safe return.

Netanyahu quickly blamed Hamas for the abduction, and authorized a major crackdown on the group. Hundreds of its members were arrested across the West Bank, thousands of homes were raided, and at least six Palestinians were killed in confrontations with Israeli soldiers.